REIMAGINING EDUCATION IN INDIA TODAY

A thought-provoking dialogue with Shri Samir Somaiya, Chancellor of Somaiya Vidyavihar University, on shaping the future of learning.

What are the biggest gaps you see in Indian higher education today, and how is Somaiya Vidyavihar University addressing them?

India is home to the world's largest youth population. Millions of young people are entering higher education with new expectations; they want relevance, flexibility, and opportunities that go far beyond the classroom.

We at Somaiya Vidyavihar University want to create great citizens of India and the world. A good education must teach the fundamentals of a student's field. At the same time, we have built an academic system that encourages students to move across disciplines, apply their learning in real-world settings, and reflect deeply on the kind of impact they want to make. Whether they're studying engineering or music, biotechnology or Sanskrit, students can combine domains, collaborate across departments, and shape their own path.

That freedom is supported by structure, through mentoring, research, field exposure, and a campus culture built on purpose, openness, and service.

Somaiya Vidyavihar University brings together different fields like engineering, AI, music, Dharma studies, and languages. Why was it important to build that kind of academic spread?

Being prepared for being gainfully employed is an important role of education institutions. Students must be prepared to be ready for the immediate present, and also the ever changing and unpredictable future. Education must also be that which expands the mind of the student and builds character. Swami Vivekanand had said, that: 'We want that education by which character is formed, strength of mind is increased, the intellect is expanded, and by which one can stand on one's own feet.'

In this, we see the description of education as being holistic. We have to focus on चेतस (अवबोध), बोध & धारित. And so in our academic structure, we are now offering a selection of a wide variety of courses within various 'baskets' that encourage students to explore areas such as Sports, the Aesthetic Arts, Nature, Dharma, Literature and Languages. This selection is mapped to the NEP and also ensures that while students excel at their chosen area of study, they also get exposed to the wider world. This widens their horizons, broadens their thinking and builds character.

How is Somaiya Vidyavihar University preparing students to work with Artificial Intelligence in real, practical ways?

AI is a powerful and emerging tool that is going to change the way we approach our daily lives. Much like the changes that occurred due to the internet earlier, mobile telephony, the telephone, or even electricity.

AI is now foundational across sectors, from climate modelling to design, governance, and policy. Our students use AI to build real-world tools, from predictive models used in public systems to innovations in agri-tech.

What has changed is the tremendous computing power that is being used to enable systems to deliver insights and perform tasks that we would otherwise take a long time to do ourselves (and maybe not be able to do at all).

Education institutions have to teach AI and Data Systems. We have to research their continuing evolution and application. Help students understand how to make their learning more powerful with the use of AI, while at the same time not becoming cognitively weak themselves.

An example of integrating AI into applications is that our students and faculty have developed Apps that can understand the vulnerability of an organisation's electronic infrastructure and then advise the organisation on how to add tools to be more impervious to cyber attacks.

These are exciting times, and we look forward to understanding and being a part of this evolving landscape.

Many institutions talk about sustainability, but not all act on it. What specific steps is Somaiya Vidyavihar University taking to reduce its environmental impact?

Sustainability is not something we teach as a subject. It's a mindset we practice across campus. We have a nice campus in the city of Mumbai. We have landscaped our gardens and



have trees and greenery all over. Our buildings reflect our history and the evolution of the community around it. Many of our buildings reflect our built heritage. We like students to think of what it is we would like to sustain - our nature, our languages, our architecture, our knowledge systems. This is in addition to the sustainability we currently talk about - referring to a circular and low carbon world.

Through CASCADÉ (Centre for Achieving Sustainable Climate Action, Development and Engagement), our students work with rural communities in Maharashtra and Karnataka to understand food and biomass systems and soil health. As we look at transitioning from an oil based to a soil based economy, we have to understand how these systems work, and how to improve the health of the soil as well as the farming community that is dependent on them. India has also created great strides in renewable energy - we have programmes that help students understand the science, the engineering, the policy and the entrepreneurship required to make this transition a reality.

Looking ahead, what do you want Somaiya Vidyavihar University to be known for in the next five to ten years?

My grandfather, Padma Bhushan Shri Karamshibhai Jethabhai Somaiya, founded this institution in 1942 with a clear belief that knowledge alone liberates. To create great citizens of India and the World.

We are aiming to provide the best teaching faculty and education infrastructure. We want our students to have access to research laboratories, libraries (physical and digital), teachers and research projects, ability to participate in global team competitions, sports, service projects and an exposure to nature and diversity.

We are located in Mumbai, the financial heartbeat of the 4th largest economy in the world. Mumbai has Dalal Street, Bollywood. Imagine adding Silicon Valley, Cambridge, Kashi and Shanti Niketan. Bring learning at the interface of discovery, innovation,science, entrepreneurship, finance, art, humanities, performing arts, film making, humanities, and spirituality. This is what we are working to make a reality.

None of this would have been possible without the vision of our founder and later his son Dr. Shantilal K Somaiya. We have a large campus in Mumbai where we are building this Vidyavihar as was his vision. It is a green oasis in Mumbai and we strive to keep it beautiful. In this we have created academic faculties that teach Engineering, Management, Education, Humanities and Social Sciences, Basic and Applied Sciences, Languages, Music and Performing Arts, Dharma Studies, Film, Fine Art, Sport, and other subjects. We have built an incubator riidl, where students can incubate their ideas.

We will continue to build infrastructure and attract teaching and research talent to build a world class teaching and research University. We want to be known as an institution that is proudly Indian, global in the reach of its ideas and universal in its service. Where our students learn to stand on their own feet, have integrity and are great citizens of India and the world.